The origins of the consultative committee come from a practice started by Nehru who used to periodically consult with close parliamentary colleagues on aspects of foreign policy before he introduced that policy in parliament.[29] Lal Bahadur Shastri continued this policy. However, there was a backlash from members of parliament who demanded the establishment of formal consultative committees instead of informal consultation. In 1969 parliamentary consultative committees were set up.

The consultative committee is ideally supposed to be comprised of representatives of all political parties roughly in proportion to their strength in parliament. The current Parliamentary Consultative Committee on External Affairs and Overseas Indian Affairs is chaired by the minister for external affairs and overseas Indian affairs. In addition, there are the two ministers of state for external affairs and two ex-officio ministers – the ministers of state for parliamentary affairs. Other members include eleven members of parliament from the Lok Sabha (Lower House of parliament) and seventeen members of parliament from the Rajya Sabha (Upper House of parliament).[30] This committee is consultative and advisory in nature. It is chaired by the external affairs minister and is a body for the minister to consult.

The standing committees too have proportionate representation from both the Houses of parliament. The current Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs is chaired by a member of the opposition, and has nineteen members of parliament from the Lok Sabha and eight from the Rajya Sabha.[31] The standing committee has the power to call the officials to testify before it. It looks over the annual reports of the Ministry of External Affairs, can ask questions about budgetary allocations and also has a veto over the budget of the Ministry of External Affairs. This committee submits its annual report to the parliament.

Supporters argue that the standing committee is like a mini-parliament and through it the parliament exercises control over the conduct of foreign